

Interview questions

Future Students about expectations (3)

1. Tell me what you've done so far to figure out your housing for when you arrive.
2. Has anything felt unclear or stressful in that process?
3. Why is that stressful for you specifically?
4. Have you actually tried to do anything about it?
5. If nothing changes and you go with your current plan, would that genuinely bother you, or is it fine?

Current students about experience (16)

1. Tell me how you did to find your housing when you moved to Madrid, start from the earliest you can remember.
2. Was there anything that felt hard or frustrating during that process?
3. Why was that hard for you specifically?
4. What did you do to try to solve it?
5. Looking back, was it actually a real problem or just a minor annoyance?

Questions asked in a totally open way, not implying anything about a possible solution. The goal is to find out if the finding of roommates is actually a pain point or if we misread it. If mentioned, we can push through on it but not push the interviewee to simply confirm our idea.

Interview insights

General insight:

Across all nineteen interviews, one pattern is consistent: the tools students currently use to find flatmates: WhatsApp groups, Facebook groups, word of mouth, ... Filter exclusively on availability and budget but never on compatibility. The result is that most students end up living with people they chose for logistical reasons rather than lifestyle fit, and the consequences range from minor daily friction to broken leases, financial losses, and genuinely unpleasant living situations. The problem is real, recurring, and felt across nationalities, genders, and program types. Nine out of nineteen interviews showed strong signal, and even the mild signal cases often revealed that a lucky outcome masked a flawed process. Several interviewees acknowledged they got fortunate rather than having made a well-informed decision.

The interviews also surfaced several compatibility dimensions that the current profile structure does not fully capture and should. Financial habits, attitudes toward shared bills, air

conditioning, groceries, emerged as a distinct friction point separate from general lifestyle. The program or schedule of a student matters significantly, as a working professional and a full-time student sharing a flat is a structural mismatch regardless of personality. Gender preference in flatmate selection came up repeatedly and organically, suggesting it should be a first-class filter rather than an afterthought. The ghost problem, promising conversations going cold in WhatsApp groups when searching, points to a product need around commitment signals and response visibility. And the late arrival or waitlist student is a specific high-urgency persona the platform should design for explicitly, as time pressure compounds every friction point.

The core concept is validated, but the profile depth needs to go further than lifestyle habits, it needs to capture financial comfort, academic schedule, and gender preference as primary matching inputs.

I think that by making a very simple MVP with different orders of importance per feature, and doing more interviews then we will be able to get more information about how the product needs to look. Right now, we're able to confirm that there is a space for the product, but we still need more information from our target customers to figure out how exactly it should look to reduce friction to a minimum.

Individual interviews insights

Future students (3)

Three incoming students were interviewed with the questions above, one boy (22) from Belgium, another boy (21) from the Netherlands with Iranian roots and one girl (22) from the Netherlands. Different insights were observed:

Interviewee 1: Male, 21, Netherlands

Joined a co-living situation through an existing friend group, some already in Madrid. On the surface a smooth outcome, but under pressure he revealed he felt pushed into it rather than having chosen it. The framing from the group was essentially "apartments are scarce, take this or risk finding nothing." He didn't reject the situation, but he would have considered alternatives if they had existed. Outcome is uncertain, it may work out well socially.

Signal: mild. The problem exists but wasn't acute enough to drive active searching. There is latent demand for optionality that was never exercised.

Interviewee 2: Male, 22, Belgium

Found one friend to live with but wanted a third flatmate at the start and couldn't find one because they have different programs and will probably not have the same schedules on the long run. Current posture is "fine with two, would have preferred three." Not actively searching anymore because it takes effort, so they accepted the situation rather than resolved it.

Signal: mild. Clear openness to a better solution if it existed, but not a felt urgency. Would

likely have used the platform passively rather than been driven to it.

**Insight from interviewer: Important to add the program they'll be studying in the matching criteria because that's the main reason they are/were looking for a third roommate.*

Interviewee 3: Female, 22, Netherlands

Strongest signal of the three. Knows only male acquaintances going to Madrid and specifically wants to live with other girls. Has already identified that living alone is too expensive and that shared apartments are objectively better value. Actively looking for female flatmates with no good tool to do it. Her current plan: wait for the IE WhatsApp group (tip from her brother who attended IE three years ago) and hope female flatmates emerge from it or wait until she finds someone through a mutual friend reacting on her Instagram stories (so mouth to ear), which she posts about every week, that also joins IE.

Signal: strong. This is the target user. She has a specific, unmet need, has already done research, has a budget constraint forcing her toward co-living, and is defaulting to a tool (WhatsApp group or through mutual contacts) that is structurally bad at solving her problem. The gap between what she needs and what the WhatsApp group can offer is exactly where Nido sits.

Current students (16)

We interviewed sixteen current students with the questions above, they are very diverse in: gender, where they're from, age, MiM or other studies but all relevant to the research. .

Interviewee 4: Male, 24, U.K.

Found his flatmates (2 boys) through a Facebook group, filtered by budget. No compatibility screening beyond that. Arrived at the end of August with two strangers, going in open-minded because it was not his first time living with people he didn't know.

The situation deteriorated progressively over lifestyle friction, not personality clashes. Three specific points of conflict emerged:

1. Sleep schedules, one flatmate went to bed significantly earlier, creating tension around noise and having people over.
2. Social habits at home, Interviewee 4 liked having guests frequently and one flatmate strongly disliked it, leading to direct arguments.
3. Bathroom sharing, one flatmate had a substantially longer morning routine, which created daily friction when schedules overlapped during the first terms.

Worth noting: the sexuality dimension came up not as a social issue but as a practical one, different morning routines tied to different habits. The discomfort was logistical, not interpersonal. This is actually a clean validation of the algorithm's lifestyle-first logic.

When asked if he would do it differently, he said he would've thought twice and done more research. (note of interviewer: he didn't have a tool that could have done that research for him, except asking questions but that's subjective)

Signal: strong. This is a textbook case of what Nido's matching layer is designed to prevent. Every friction point that emerged: sleep schedule, social habits at home, bathroom rhythm. Maps directly onto the "Who I am" profile fields already in the product

Interviewee 5: Male, 26, Germany

Arrived in Madrid knowing nobody. Decided against searching for flatmates through WhatsApp groups, didn't trust the process and didn't want to live with strangers. Chose to rent alone at €2,500/month. After roughly three months, had built enough of a social circle to identify someone he actually wanted to live with. At that point he broke his lease, absorbed an extra month's rent as penalty, and moved in with a German friend he'd met in the interim

The situation resolved well socially, but the financial cost of the path he took was significant: roughly €7,500+ spent on solo rent plus the penalty month before landing in a situation he was actually comfortable with.

Signal: strong, but different from the others. This isn't a compatibility failure or a chaotic search, it's a trust problem. He had a solution available (WhatsApp group) and rejected it because he couldn't assess who he'd be living with. The cost of that distrust was real and quantifiable. Nido's trust mechanic: university email gate, profile depth, compatibility scoring, ... is precisely what would have changed his calculus.

Interviewee 6: Female, 23, France

Arrived in Madrid for her master's knowing one person from her undergrad, who ended up not coming. Found a Facebook group, messaged around twenty people over two weeks, got three replies. Moved in with two Spanish girls she couldn't properly assess beforehand because their English was limited and conversations stayed surface level. Turned out one was barely ever home and the other had friends over until 3am on weekdays regularly. She stuck it out for the full year but described it as "liveable but exhausting." Said the core issue was never having had a real conversation about expectations before signing the lease.

Signal: strong. Classic lifestyle mismatch born from zero compatibility screening. The language barrier made pre-assessment even harder, a profile-based system would remove that dependency.

Interviewee 7: Male, 22, France

Came to Madrid with two friends from his home university doing the same program. The three of them found an apartment together within two weeks through Idealista, no flatmate search needed. Experience was smooth. Only friction mentioned was the apartment hunt itself and landlords asking for Spanish guarantors, but socially zero issues.

Signal: mild. The non-users profile. No need for the platform at this stage. Landlord barrier is

noted but outside our scope.

Interviewee 8: Female, 24, Argentina

Found her flatmates through the IE WhatsApp group. Messaged several people, ended up with two others she felt reasonably good about based on a few voice notes and Instagram profile checks. One flatmate turned out to be a great match, the other was fine but they never really connected. Said she would have liked a more structured way to assess compatibility beforehand but acknowledged the outcome was acceptable. Not unhappy, just aware it could have been better.

Signal: partial. Conscious of the gap between her vetting process and what she actually needed. Would have used a structured tool if it existed but wasn't distressed enough to seek one out actively.

Interviewee 9: Male, 21, Italy

Arrived late, was on vacation until 2 days before the start of the program. Had no time to search properly and ended up in a short-term Airbnb for the first month at significant cost while looking for something permanent. Eventually found a room in a shared flat through a friend of a friend, but described the first month as genuinely stressful and financially damaging. Said the biggest problem was not knowing who was looking for a flatmate at the same time as him and at the same budget and therefore there was no place where that information was visible and trustworthy. If he had found a flatmate earlier, he could've helped him find a place and avoid the Airbnb.

Signal: strong. Time pressure amplified every friction point. The core need: finding compatible people searching simultaneously, is exactly what the platform surfaces.

Interviewee 10: Male, 23, Netherlands

Joined an existing flatshare that had an open room, found through a post in the IE Whatsapp group. The existing two flatmates interviewed him over a video call before agreeing. He found the process fine, slightly awkward to be "interviewed" but appreciated that it meant the group was serious about compatibility. Settled in well. Mentioned he got lucky that the existing group happened to match his lifestyle but acknowledged that wasn't guaranteed in all situations.

Signal: mild. Scenario A in practice, joining an existing group. The outcome was good but he acknowledged luck played a role. The platform would have made the matching explicit rather than coincidental.

Interviewee 11: Male, 22, Belgium

Got pulled into a flatshare by two acquaintances, one was a good friend's brother, the other someone he barely knew. Didn't search at all, just accepted. The third flatmate worked full-time while the other two were students, creating a fundamental schedule mismatch, he was asleep by 10pm while the others kept student hours. Tensions escalated to the point

where he eventually left the apartment. Notably, the three get along fine outside the flat, the issue was never personal incompatibility, purely lifestyle incompatibility. A profile check would have flagged the mismatch immediately before anyone signed anything.

Signal: strong. Clean illustration that being friends, or friendly, is not a proxy for compatible living. The app's lifestyle layer is precisely what was missing here.

Interviewee 12: Female, 22, France

Knew nobody going to Madrid. Found flatmates through a Facebook group, missed the WhatsApp group entirely. Ended up with two girls and one boy from different schools with different priorities. The social dynamic within the flat turned cold, small incidents like flatmates taking their laundry in during rain and leaving hers outside became representative of a broader lack of solidarity. Recurring friction points included air conditioning usage and shared bills, where different financial comfort levels created daily tension.

Signal: strong. Two distinct layers of incompatibility: social values and financial habits, neither of which a budget-only or network-only filter catches. Both are addressable in the profile structure.

Interviewee 13: Male, 25, Spain

Already living in Madrid when he started his program at IE. Stayed in his existing apartment alone rather than searching for flatmates, had the financial means and preferred the privacy. No search stress, no compatibility issues. Mentioned in passing that some classmates had chaotic experiences finding housing but personally had no problem.

Signal: mild. Outside the target use case entirely, local student with existing housing. Not a user.

Interviewee 14: Female, 22, Portugal

Arrived two weeks before the program started. Found the IE WhatsApp group months before but thought it was very vague. Spent three weeks messaging people, had several promising conversations that went cold, and eventually moved into a flat with one person she felt okay about and one girl she had never spoken to, the third was chosen by the second flatmate without her input. Ended up with a functional but uncomfortable living situation. Said the worst part was having no way to know if someone was serious or just keeping options open. So in the end she just joined the easiest one because it would give her security about having housing at least.

Signal: strong. The WhatsApp group's core failure: no structure, no commitment signals, no compatibility layer, articulated clearly. The ghost problem (conversations going cold) is also a product consideration.

Interviewee 15: Male, 23, Mexico

Found flatmates through a mutual friend network, a friend of a friend recommended a group

with an open spot. Moved in without much vetting. The situation worked out reasonably well but he noted that one flatmate was significantly messier than him and it created low-level ongoing friction. Not a dealbreaker, but something he thought about. Said he'd probably be more deliberate next time.

Signal: partial. Cleanliness mismatch, one of the core profile fields, present but not severe enough to cause real damage. Aware that a better process existed, not motivated enough to have sought it out.

Interviewee 16: Female, 25, Japan

International student, arrived with no European network. Spent six weeks in a student residence while searching for a permanent flat. The residence was expensive and she described the search period as genuinely exhausting: language barrier with landlords, rejection from apartments requiring local guarantors, and no reliable way to find flatmates searching at the same time with the same budget. Eventually found a group through a Facebook expat group but described the vetting process as vague and exhausting.

Signal: strong. Stacks multiple pain points: guarantor barrier, language barrier, no simultaneous search visibility on top of the core compatibility gap. Residence as expensive interim solution is like we saw in Interviewee 9.

Interviewee 17: Male, 22, Netherlands

Came to Madrid having already connected with two Dutch classmates through LinkedIn before arrival. The three agreed to live together before the program started and found an apartment through Idealista within a week. Smooth experience from start to finish. Mentioned the landlord process was annoying but the flatmate side was never a concern.

Signal: mild. Already sorted via LinkedIn pre-networking. Represents the subset of students proactive enough to build connections before arrival which is a small minority.

Interviewee 18: Female, 23, Germany

Found her flatmates through the IE WhatsApp group. Was quite deliberate about it, had several video calls before agreeing, asked specific questions to make sure they were on the same page. Said it took significantly more effort than it should have and she got lucky that the people she ended up with were also willing to have those conversations. One flatmate was great, one was fine. Felt the process was unnecessarily long and stressful given that everyone involved was looking for the same thing.

Signal: partial. Self-solved the problem through effort that the platform would have automated. Conscious of the friction, resourceful enough to overcome it. Would have been a power user.

Interviewee 19: Male, 24, Colombia

First time living abroad. Had no idea where to start, didn't know about the WhatsApp group,

didn't know about Facebook groups. Spent the first month in an Airbnb burning through budget while figuring out the landscape. Eventually found a room in a shared flat through a classmate tip but had no say in who the other flatmates were. Took the room, not the people. Described one flatmate as "impossible to live with", extremely loud at night, dismissive of shared space rules. Left after four months, took a financial hit on the deposit. Then went to live with friends he made at IE who'd had similar types of problems.

Signal: strong. Worst outcome in the dataset: financial loss, lifestyle mismatch, early exit to then live with the people he should've lived with from the start. Discovery failure compounded by compatibility failure. Both addressable.

Interviewee 20: Male, age 23, Lebanon

Searched for housing independently ahead of a September program start. Despite a high budget, repeatedly ran into listings that were either unavailable or over his ceiling by the time he contacted agencies. Found something last minute in August, describing the experience as very stressful. His frustration was directed primarily at the supply-demand imbalance in Madrid's rental market rather than at the flatmate search process itself. No mention of who he ended up living with, how compatibility was assessed, or whether the social outcome of his housing situation was positive or negative.

Signal: mild. The pain point surfaced here is availability and affordability, not flatmate matching. The stress was real and the timing pressure is consistent with the late-arrival persona seen in Interviewees 9 and 16, but the interview didn't reach the compatibility layer. Worth a follow-up to understand his current living situation and whether friction emerged after moving in.

Note from interviewer: the interview was short and didn't go deep enough to assess the flatmate dimension. The housing scarcity frustration is real context but doesn't validate or invalidate the core concept.

Interviewee 21: Male, age 25, Spain

Already had partial roots in Madrid through his sister and her network. Found his apartment through a contact of his sister's, posted on Idealista. Now lives with his sister. Described the search as "not that bad" and credited his outcome to having people in the city already. Main friction was price relative to quality: he considers the apartment overpriced for what it is, though acceptable given the location. When asked what he'd do differently, his only answer was to start earlier.

Signal: mild. This is the local-network case, comparable to Interviewee 7 and Interviewee 17: a pre-existing relationship solved the search problem before it became one. He never needed to assess a stranger's compatibility because he never searched for one. The overpricing frustration is consistent across the dataset but is a market problem outside the product's scope. Not a target user in his current situation, though his framing ("having people here made it way easier") implicitly confirms the gap for students who arrive without that network.

